Internship Report

M E Clarke Consulting, LLC

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M.A. in English: Professional Writing
University of Cincinnati

Date of Internship: May 19 – December 12
Credited: Fall 2025

First Reader: Chenxing Xie
Second Reader: Lora Anderson

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Job Description

As a Communications and Storytelling Intern, I supported M E Clarke Consulting, LLC (MECC) in enhancing brand visibility by sharing client success stories for a broad digital audience across multiple platforms. My day-to-day tasks included **copywriting**, **graphic design**, and **internal communication** to generate **social media campaigns** with an emphasis on storytelling and digital engagement. Particularly, I created copy and flyers advertising the Lead Like it Matters Retreat Series, a monthly event in which participants learn about leadership values through guided reflections and group discussion. Here, I describe the MECC organization and how my main responsibilities were oriented within it.

M E Clarke Consulting, LLC

MECC is a work culture consulting firm founded in 2008 that counsels organizations and professionals to enhance internal team-building and leadership in their workplaces. MECC is proudly women-led and acknowledges the difficulty of leadership, focusing the practice around healing, active listening, and inclusivity among working teams of all industries. Their clients include Oberlin College, the University of Cincinnati, and P&G.

- Meghan Clarke: Founder of MECC and Practitioner.
- Kristi Lee: Practitioner who left the team in July.
- Kate McCracken: Practitioner who joined the team in August.
- Grace Middleton: Business Consultant.

MECC operates from an office in Blue Ash in a space named The Encounter which features a communal kitchen, open concept meeting spaces, and two private conference rooms. The space has three primary uses: 1) internal MECC meetings and retreats, 2) work retreats for clients led by an MECC practitioner, 3) a rental space for clients to host events.

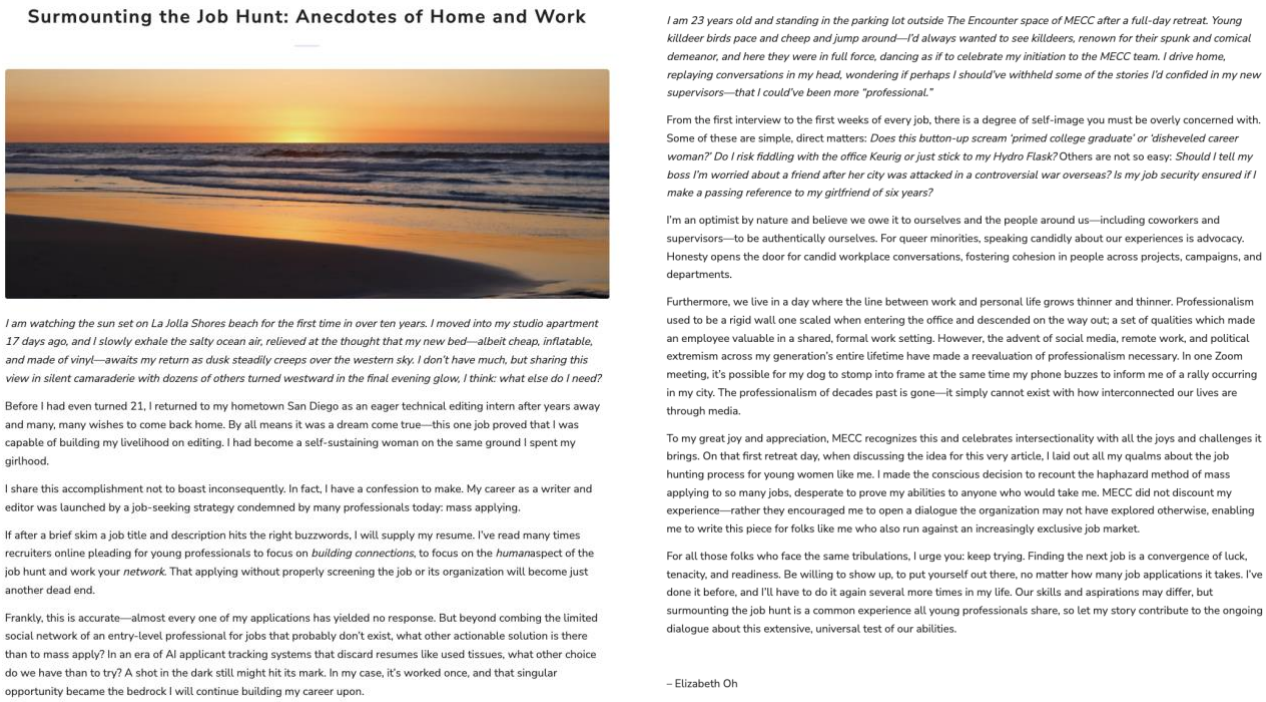
My position as a Communications and Storytelling Intern was remote, though I would participate in retreats at The Encounter once or twice a month. I worked ten hours each week of the summer semester, bookended by check-in meetings with Grace on Mondays then check-out meetings with the full team on Thursdays. With Meghan's approval, I worked occasionally during the fall semester, and on December 13th I will give a presentation to the team about my experience, incorporating the contents of this report.

Copywriting

The majority of my copywriting work for MECC concerned written content that complemented and supported the organization's visual and marketing materials. My primary projects included blog writing, newsletter composition, and copywriting marketing materials.

For the MECC blog, I authored two posts: one case study featuring MECC's partnership with the Oberlin College IT team and a personal story about my experience navigating the early stages of a job search. The Oberlin case study required translating internal notes and event documentation into a cohesive, reader-friendly narrative that highlighted MECC's consulting approach (though this case study has not yet been published). I worked closely with Kristi—the consultant who

consulted with Oberlin for years—through several rounds of revision to ensure I accurately portrayed the relationship between MECC and Oberlin. In contrast, my job hunt blog was more personal and conversational, designed to tell an engaging story to readers through shared experience while aligning with MECC's emphasis on authenticity and leadership development (Figure 1). I was encouraged to be creative and invite my own narrative voice into the article, something I have not been able to do outside of creative writing spaces. As a result of both these projects, I was able to craft original stories by uniting my creativity with the experience and encouragement of MECC.



Surmounting the Job Hunt: Anecdotes of Home and Work

I am watching the sun set on La Jolla Shores beach for the first time in over ten years. I moved into my studio apartment 17 days ago, and I slowly exhale the salty ocean air, relieved at the thought that my new bed—albeit cheap, inflatable, and made of vinyl—awaits my return as dusk steadily creeps over the western sky. I don't have much, but sharing this view in silent camaraderie with dozens of others turned westward in the final evening glow, I think: what else do I need?

Before I had even turned 21, I returned to my hometown San Diego as an eager technical editing intern after years away and many, many wishes to come back home. By all means it was a dream come true—this one job proved that I was capable of building my livelihood on editing. I had become a self-sustaining woman on the same ground I spent my girlhood.

I share this accomplishment not to boast inconsequently. In fact, I have a confession to make. My career as a writer and editor was launched by a job-seeking strategy condemned by many professionals today: mass applying.

If after a brief skim a job title and description hits the right buzzwords, I will supply my resume. I've read many times recruiters online pleading for young professionals to focus on *building connections*, to focus on the *human*aspect of the job hunt and work your *network*. That applying without properly screening the job or its organization will become just another dead end.

Frankly, this is accurate—almost every one of my applications has yielded no response. But beyond combing the limited social network of an entry-level professional for jobs that probably don't exist, what other actionable solution is there than to mass apply? In an era of AI applicant tracking systems that discard resumes like used tissues, what other choice do we have than to try? A shot in the dark still might hit its mark. In my case, it's worked once, and that singular opportunity became the bedrock I will continue building my career upon.

I am 23 years old and standing in the parking lot outside The Encounter space of MECC after a full-day retreat. Young killdeer birds pace and cheep and jump around—I'd always wanted to see killdeers, renown for their spunk and comical demeanor, and here they were in full force, dancing as if to celebrate my initiation to the MECC team. I drive home, replaying conversations in my head, wondering if perhaps I should've withheld some of the stories I'd confided in my new supervisors—that I could've been more "professional."

From the first interview to the first weeks of every job, there is a degree of self-image you must be overly concerned with. Some of these are simple, direct matters: *Does this button-up scream 'primed college graduate' or 'disheveled career woman?' Do I risk fiddling with the office Keurig or just stick to my Hydro Flask?* Others are not so easy: *Should I tell my boss I'm worried about a friend after her city was attacked in a controversial war overseas? Is my job security ensured if I make a passing reference to my girlfriend of six years?*

I'm an optimist by nature and believe we owe it to ourselves and the people around us—including coworkers and supervisors—to be authentically ourselves. For queer minorities, speaking candidly about our experiences is advocacy. Honesty opens the door for candid workplace conversations, fostering cohesion in people across projects, campaigns, and departments.

Furthermore, we live in a day where the line between work and personal life grows thinner and thinner. Professionalism used to be a rigid wall one scaled when entering the office and descended on the way out; a set of qualities which made an employee valuable in a shared, formal work setting. However, the advent of social media, remote work, and political extremism across my generation's entire lifetime have made a reevaluation of professionalism necessary. In one Zoom meeting, it's possible for my dog to stomp into frame at the same time my phone buzzes to inform me of a rally occurring in my city. The professionalism of decades past is gone—it simply cannot exist with how interconnected our lives are through media.

To my great joy and appreciation, MECC recognizes this and celebrates intersectionality with all the joys and challenges it brings. On that first retreat day, when discussing the idea for this very article, I laid out all my qualms about the job hunting process for young women like me. I made the conscious decision to recount the haphazard method of mass applying to so many jobs, desperate to prove my abilities to anyone who would take me. MECC did not discount my experience—rather they encouraged me to open a dialogue the organization may not have explored otherwise, enabling me to write this piece for folks like me who also run against an increasingly exclusive job market.

For all those folks who face the same tribulations, I urge you: keep trying. Finding the next job is a convergence of luck, tenacity, and readiness. Be willing to show up, to put yourself out there, no matter how many job applications it takes. I've done it before, and I'll have to do it again several more times in my life. Our skills and aspirations may differ, but surmounting the job hunt is a common experience all young professionals share, so let my story contribute to the ongoing dialogue about this extensive, universal test of our abilities.

– Elizabeth Oh

Figure 1: Personal blog article.

I also drafted the August and September newsletter issues, featuring original copy in the introduction and team insight section, containing a quote, recommended reading, and featured blog piece (Figure 2). This process required balancing informational clarity with an approachable, community-oriented tone.

ME CLARKE consulting LLC

Pauli Murray: Living Their Legacy Today

Pauli Murray was a poet, priest, lawyer, legal strategist. A leader who was black, gender nonconforming, and queer. A human rights architect. A quiet thunder. And yet—for many of us—Pauli's name didn't enter our orbit in any history class or lecture.

Almost a century ago, far before the term *intersectionality* was coined, Pauli was living at the center of overlapping identities, blazing a legal career into uncharted territory to recognize and organize against gender discrimination.

They are a vivid reminder that, despite the rollback of so many civil rights our country has witnessed in recent years, Pauli championed an inclusive future for women, people of color, and LGBTQ+ folks before most of us were even born.

I find myself compelled to compare myself to Pauli, perhaps because so many of our qualities overlap. We are writers, poets, academics, minorities, same-gender loving people. As a wasian queer woman, I feel that I occupy a narrow niche that is not widely acknowledged nor documented. I feel like a *first* in many senses, just as Pauli was a *first* in so many occupations. First African American to receive a Doctor of Juridicial Science from Yale, first female-presenting African American person to become an Episcopal priest. It is a great comfort to walk the trail Pauli blazed in the name of equity—to take respite from our modern plights in the shade of their great, lofty shadow.

We move forward by recognizing the champions of our past that fought for our privileges today. In some cases, the privileges that are under threat of revocation in the very near future.

We owe it to Pauli and ourselves to continue the fight, to elevate the history and champions that predate us before we suffer a lapse of self and lose our next Pauli, our next civil right, our next battleground.

— Elizabeth

Read "Why Don't We Know Pauli Murray?"

What's Working Us...

Quote We're Thinking About...
"When my brothers try to draw a circle to exclude me, I shall draw a larger circle to include them. Where they speak out for the privileges of a puny group, I shall shout for the rights of all mankind." — Pauli Murray

What We're Reading...
Need a place to start living Pauli's legacy of inclusive education? In ***Unfamiliar Fishes***, Sarah Vowell traces the history of Hawai'i from the time of its Polynesian settlers to the present post-colonial day in an extensive, compact narrative of its most prominent leaders and events. If you're eager to learn about the multifaceted face of our 50th state, this book is an excellent place to start.

What's New on the Blog...
In case you missed it, we're celebrating Kristi's time with us.

Figure 2: August newsletter.

I also drafted copy for LinkedIn posts to promote events, blogs, and organizational updates (Figure 3). These brief posts emphasized concise, active language and incorporated SEO phrases to increase visibility and engagement across MECC's audience, skills I learned across RPW classes like **PWRT 7045 Web Design** (see Assessment section).

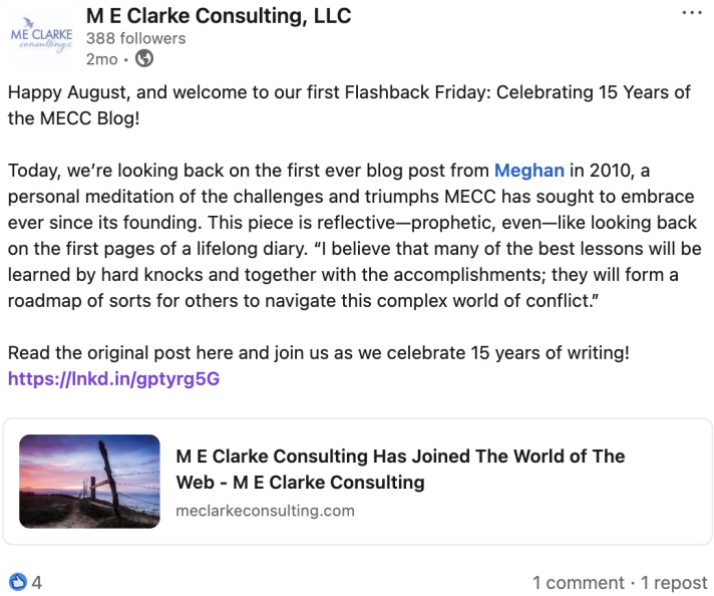


Figure 3: First Flashback Friday post on LinkedIn.

Across all writing tasks, I aimed to align MECC's voice—professional, personable, and affirming—with accessible storytelling and digital promotional.

Graphic Design

Most products I created for MECC were flyers which advertised upcoming events, particularly the Lead Like it Matters Retreat Series. For each of the five retreat series events, I created a flyer and social media banner which were posted on LinkedIn, EventBrite, and the MECC website. I created all visual promotional materials in Canva and the newsletters in Constant Contact. Drafts typically went through one or three rounds of synchronous review by Meghan and Grace when they would suggest changes in terminology or visuals to best align with the brand image. With each product, Meghan and Grace were incredibly enthusiastic and often deferred to my judgement.

MECC uses a style guide which contains basic information to maintain consistency across visual media and copy the organization publishes. Included are the primary, secondary, and tertiary brand colors; typefaces and fonts; and various iterations of the MECC logo. Though I was highly encouraged to experiment and create original designs—especially because Kristi, creator of the style guide, left MECC in July—this style guide acted as a foundation for all my projects.

From the beginning, I was granted creative freedom to draft these materials. Though I kept some elements consistent (especially the Futura font and hex codes in the brand's color palette), I invited some of my own personal flair into the pieces. For example, I implemented decorative qualities to add texture to these otherwise flat, digital pieces: the "LEAD LIKE IT MATTERS" title is overlaid atop a paint stroke in low-opacity, just enough to stand out from the background scene (Figure 4). I also used elements across flyers like paint or nature to add a sense of cohesion across pieces so viewers could easily identify the MECC brand just by the use of color and objects.

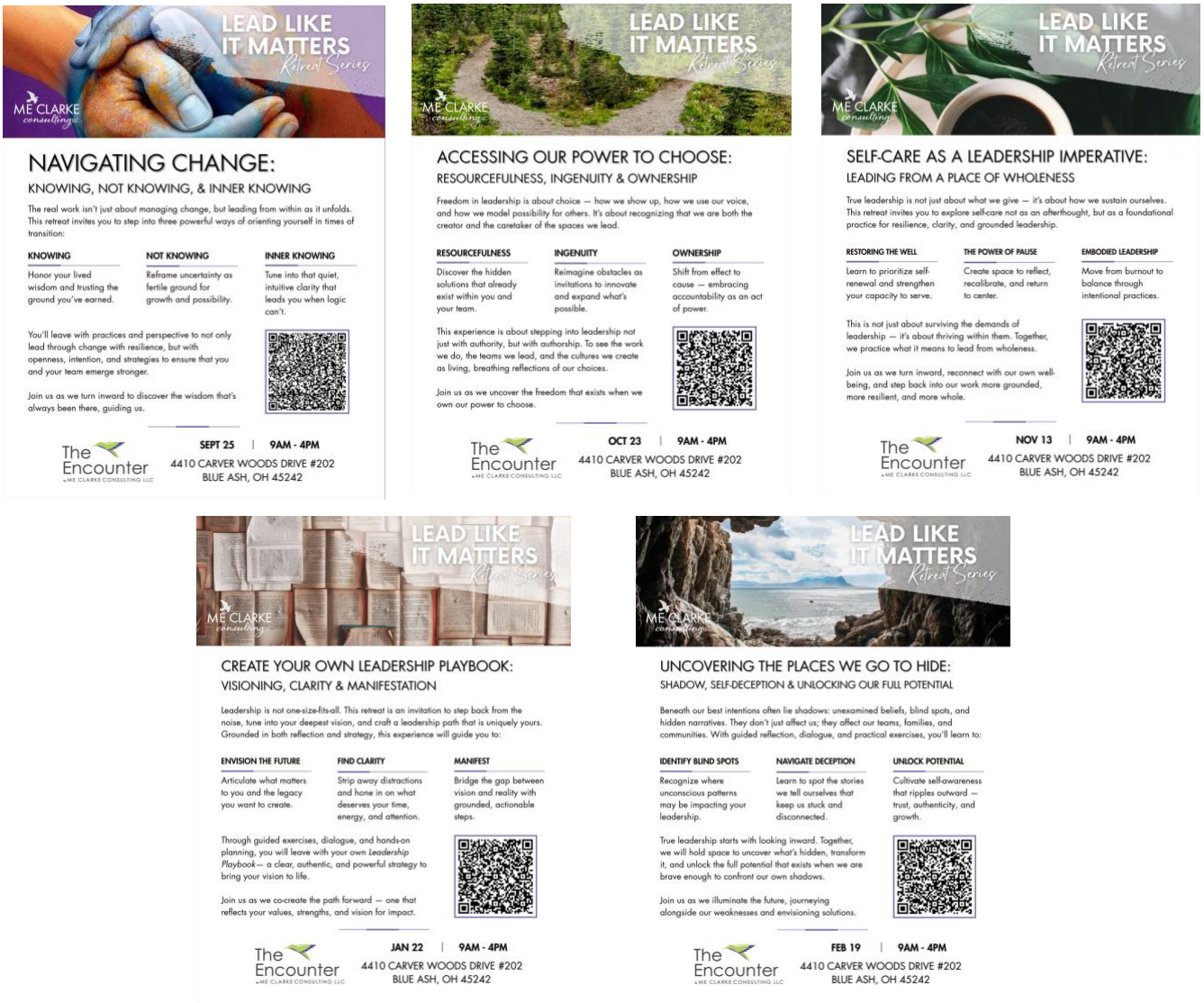
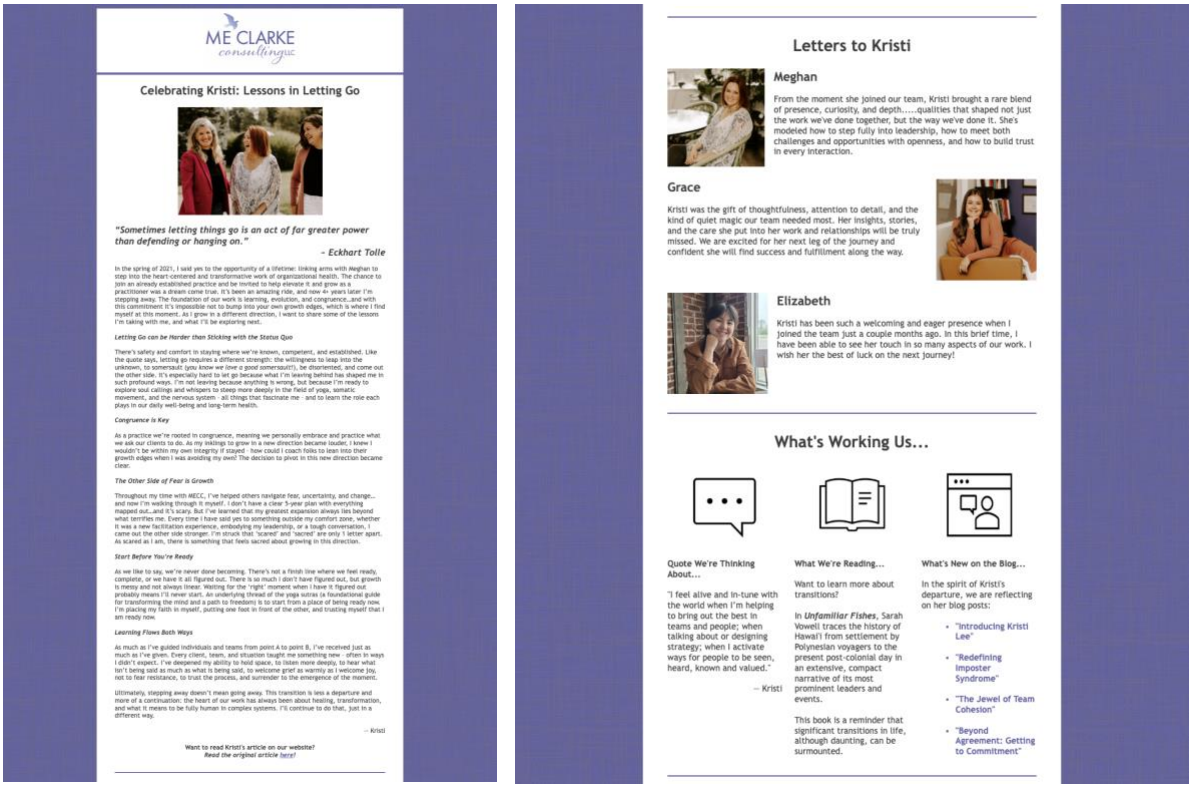


Figure 4: All five "Lead Like it Matters Retreat Series" flyers.

A refreshed newsletter format was another significant product from my time as an intern (Figure 5). Like the flyers, I added the appearance of texture in the fabric-like purple borders on either side of the newsletter content to lend a distinct, homey theme. Decorative images diversify the text-heavy, including of the MECC team and icons on the newsletter's featured quote, recommended reading, and blog articles. The overall result is a newsletter which better utilizes white space and images for a more aesthetically-pleasing, organized style.



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Celebrating Kristi: Lessons in Letting Go

"Sometimes letting things go is an act of far greater power than defending or hanging on."

– Eckhart Tolle

In the spring of 2021, I said yes to the opportunity of a lifetime: linking arms with Meghan to step into the heart-centered and transformative work of organizational health. The chance to join an already established practice and be invited to help elevate it and grow as a practitioner was a dream come true. It's been an amazing ride, and now 4+ years later I'm stepping away. The foundation of our work is learning, evolution, and congruence…and with this commitment it's impossible not to bump into your own growth edges, which is where I find myself at this moment. As I grow in a different direction, I want to share some of the lessons I'm taking with me, and what I'll be exploring next.

Letting Go can be Harder than Sticking with the Status Quo

There's safety and comfort in staying where we're known, competent, and established. Like the quote says, letting go requires a different strength: the willingness to leap into the unknown, to somersault (you know we love a good somersault!), be disoriented, and come out the other side. It's especially hard to let go because what I'm leaving behind has shaped me in such profound ways. I'm not leaving because anything is wrong, but because I'm ready to explore soul callings and whispers to sleep more deeply in the field of yoga, somatic movement, and the nervous system – all things that fascinate me – and to learn the role each plays in our daily well-being and long-term health.

Congruence is Key

As a practice we're rooted in congruence, meaning we personally embrace and practice what we ask our clients to do. As my inklings to grow in a new direction became louder, I knew I wouldn't be within my own integrity if stayed – how could I coach folks to lean into their growth edges when I was avoiding my own? The decision to pivot in this new direction became clear.

The Other Side of Fear is Growth

Throughout my time with MECC, I've helped others navigate fear, uncertainty, and change… and now I'm walking through it myself. I don't have a clear 5-year plan with everything mapped out…and it's scary. But I've learned that my greatest expansion always lies beyond what terrifies me. Every time I have said yes to something outside my comfort zone, whether it was a new facilitation experience, embodying my leadership, or a tough conversation, I came out the other side stronger. I'm struck that 'scared' and 'sacred' are only 1 letter apart. As scared as I am, there is something that feels sacred about growing in this direction.

Start Before You're Ready

As we like to say, we're never done becoming. There's not a finish line where we feel ready, complete, or we have it all figured out. There is so much I don't have figured out, but growth is messy and not always linear. Waiting for the 'right' moment when I have it figured out probably means I'll never start. An underlying thread of the yoga sutras (a foundational guide for transforming the mind and a path to freedom) is to start from a place of being ready now. I'm placing my faith in myself, putting one foot in front of the other, and trusting myself that I am ready now.

Learning Flows Both Ways

As much as I've guided individuals and teams from point A to point B, I've received just as much as I've given. Every client, team, and situation taught me something new – often in ways I didn't expect. I've deepened my ability to hold space, to listen more deeply, to hear what isn't being said as much as what is being said, to welcome grief as warmly as I welcome joy, not to fear resistance, to trust the process, and surrender to the emergence of the moment.

Ultimately, stepping away doesn't mean going away. This transition is less a departure and more of a continuation: the heart of our work has always been about healing, transformation, and what it means to be fully human in complex systems. I'll continue to do that, just in a different way.

– Kristi

Want to read Kristi's article on our website?
Read the original article here!

Letters to Kristi

Meghan

From the moment she joined our team, Kristi brought a rare blend of presence, curiosity, and depth.....qualities that shaped not just the work we've done together, but the way we've done it. She's modeled how to step fully into leadership, how to meet both challenges and opportunities with openness, and how to build trust in every interaction.

Grace

Kristi was the gift of thoughtfulness, attention to detail, and the kind of quiet magic our team needed most. Her insights, stories, and the care she put into her work and relationships will be truly missed. We are excited for her next leg of the journey and confident she will find success and fulfillment along the way.

Elizabeth

Kristi has been such a welcoming and eager presence when I joined the team just a couple months ago. In this brief time, I have been able to see her touch in so many aspects of our work. I wish her the best of luck on the next journey!

What's Working Us...

Quote We're Thinking About...

"I feel alive and in-tune with the world when I'm helping to bring out the best in teams and people; when talking about or designing strategy; when I activate ways for people to be seen, heard, known and valued."

– Kristi

What We're Reading...

Want to learn more about transitions?

In ***Unfamiliar Fishes***, Sarah Vowell traces the history of Hawai'i from settlement by Polynesian voyagers to the present post-colonial day in an extensive, compact narrative of its most prominent leaders and events.

This book is a reminder that significant transitions in life, although daunting, can be surmounted.

What's New on the Blog...

In the spirit of Kristi's departure, we are reflecting on her blog posts:

- "Introducing Kristi Lee"
- "Redefining Imposter Syndrome"
- "The Jewel of Team Cohesion"
- "Beyond Agreement: Getting to Commitment"

Figure 5: Redesigned newsletter format, featuring the September issue.

On occasion, I was asked to create flyers for new events or pre-established services that needed new publicity (Figure 6). For example, Meghan and Grace attended a conference where they would advertise the upcoming Lead Like it Matters Retreat Series, so in advance I created an overview graphic that incorporated the visual elements of each of the five flyers I designed in this series. I also created a flyer for the brief Leadership Wisdom Circle series and Leadership Coaching service at various points of the internship.

Figure 6: Assorted graphics, including the Lead Like it Matters Retreat Series overview, Leadership Wisdom Circle flyer, and Leadership Coaching flyer.

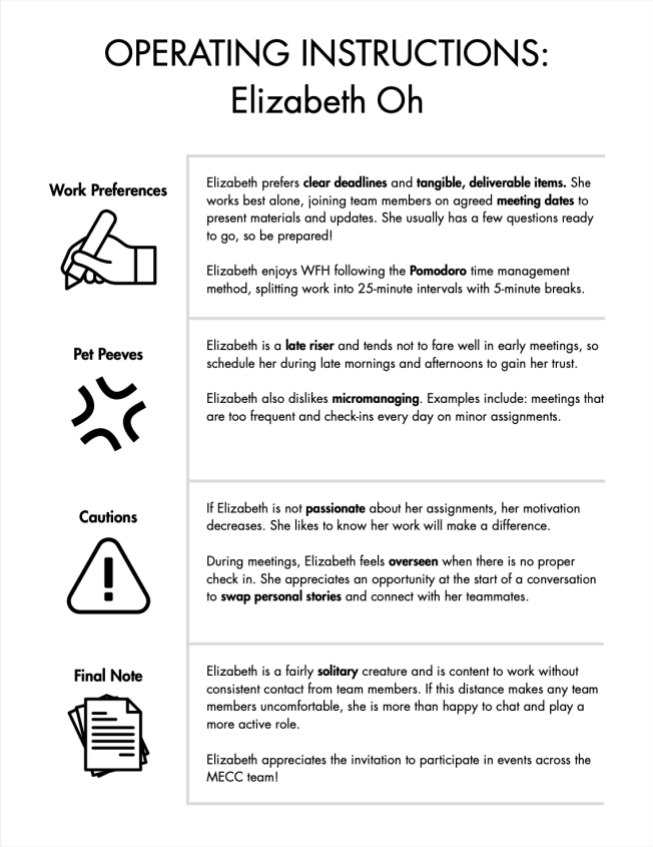
My experience in RPW classes such as **PWRT 7043 Science & Health** and **PWRT 7045 Web Design** informed my decision to uphold this consistent visual style across platforms. Through these courses, I learned how visual consistency strengthens credibility and usability, particularly in professional and informational contexts. Applying these principles at MECC allowed me to make intentional design choices that reinforced the organization's brand identity while ensuring that materials remained clear, engaging, and accessible to a wide audience.

In total, I produced a wide variety of graphics which were used across all of MECC's platforms. These graphics are a new, refreshed evolution of the MECC brand at the intersection of my own design preferences and the gentle ethos of MECC.

Communication & Social Media

Internal communication and social media engagement at MECC involved both outward-facing campaigns and internal documentation aimed at improving teamwork within our small, 4-person unit. I helped plan and execute social media campaigns, most notably the Flashback Friday series on LinkedIn which highlights memorable articles across 15-year-old MECC blog (Figure 3). These posts serve to celebrate MECC's history and encourage audience engagement between the website and LinkedIn. To plan which articles would be featured, I created a Google Sheet calendar which contained links to the articles, personal notes, original copy summarizing the article, and a proposed date for the LinkedIn post. The Flashback Friday campaign was the first social media series of its kind which I executed from outline to publication—the enthusiasm of everyone at MECC was incredibly uplifting and encouraging, and to see the campaign continue even after my departure has affirmed the importance of my work.

Internally, I participated in monthly retreats to help build camaraderie within our small team, generate ideas for campaigns or upcoming events, and identify places for improvement. Many of the consulting practices MECC employs with clients are also practiced internally, so I was able to experience the reflective pedagogies that help so many of their clients identify opportunities for growth. One of these practices was the Operating Instructions assignment, a brief worksheet which asks individuals to consider the strategies that best support them in the workplace. I took initiative in developing an original worksheet design which MECC may use when working with teams in the future—one of many instances I was encouraged to go a step beyond and use both my design and writing skills to create a useful product (Figure 7).



OPERATING INSTRUCTIONS:
Elizabeth Oh

Work Preferences

Elizabeth prefers **clear deadlines** and **tangible, deliverable items.** She works best alone, joining team members on agreed **meeting dates** to present materials and updates. She usually has a few questions ready to go, so be prepared!

Elizabeth enjoys WFH following the **Pomodoro** time management method, splitting work into 25-minute intervals with 5-minute breaks.

Pet Peeves

Elizabeth is a **late riser** and tends not to fare well in early meetings, so schedule her during late mornings and afternoons to gain her trust.

Elizabeth also dislikes **micromanaging**. Examples include: meetings that are too frequent and check-ins every day on minor assignments.

Cautions

If Elizabeth is not **passionate** about her assignments, her motivation decreases. She likes to know her work will make a difference.

During meetings, Elizabeth feels **overseen** when there is no proper check in. She appreciates an opportunity at the start of a conversation to **swap personal stories** and connect with her teammates.

Final Note

Elizabeth is a fairly **solitary** creature and is content to work without consistent contact from team members. If this distance makes any team members uncomfortable, she is more than happy to chat and play a more active role.

Elizabeth appreciates the invitation to participate in events across the MECC team!

Figure 7: Completed version of the new Operating Instructions worksheet.

While my participation in team retreats was not a formal requirement, these experiences taught me how organizations can function in healthy, collaborative ways. By observing and participating in team activities including whiteboard brainstorms, holistic check-ins, and reflection ceremonies, I gained valuable insight into how MECC fosters inclusivity and honesty in workplaces. I now have a toolkit for identifying effective strategies to foster a positive workplace culture that I wouldn't have developed if not for this experience with MECC.

As RPW classes emphasize audience awareness and rhetorical appeals, I was able to think critically about tone, clarity, and purpose when contributing ideas for audience outreach in a team setting, just as I'd done to complete assignments with classmates. As a result, I was able to participate more confidently in collaborative brainstorming sessions, offering ideas grounded not only in personal experience but also in rhetorical principles developed through my writing coursework.

I was also able to offer a fresh perspective on how MECC might improve engagement across its social media accounts by inviting in my experience as a young designer with personal and professional experience online. Brainstorming sessions were particularly generative, allowing me to share ideas about audience outreach while learning from the team's collective approach to collaboration. Flashback Friday was a result of one of these sessions, for example. This combination of communication strategy, reflective practice, and creative input made the and internal communication social media aspects of my internship especially rewarding.

Assessment

This assessment evaluates my internship experience at MECC by examining the workplace environment, the responsibilities I held, and the educational value of the position. It reflects on how the organization supported my personal and professional growth while also considering how my classwork informed my contributions. Throughout this evaluation, I assess the extent to which the internship met its learning objectives and prepared me for future work.

MECC's inclusive environment and collaborative practices shaped my growth as a burgeoning industry writer, strengthened my understanding of team dynamics, and bridged the gap between my classwork and practical, industry-based work with clients. On my first day at MECC, I was welcomed into the team with a warmth I hadn't before received at other internships. I participated in the team building exercises MECC uses internally and with their clients, including a welcome ceremony and declarations of honest excitement for my inclusion.

Also very helpful were the DiSC and Working Genius assessments I completed while onboarding which placed me on a work-styles spectrum designed by professionals in psychology and communication (Lencioni 2022). As a young professional, this experience was invaluable—it gave me early insight into my personal strengths and how these traits function in a collaborative environment. For example, I learned that I had a very peculiar Working Genius: my two strengths are on opposing sides, meaning I have the ability to consider solutions from both high-order and low-order perspectives. However, I struggle with bridging the gap between these differing angles (see Figure 8). Between the research-backed assessments and positivity on this first day, I immediately felt at ease with MECC; I felt that they truly were interested in my personal, holistic growth even beyond the internship.

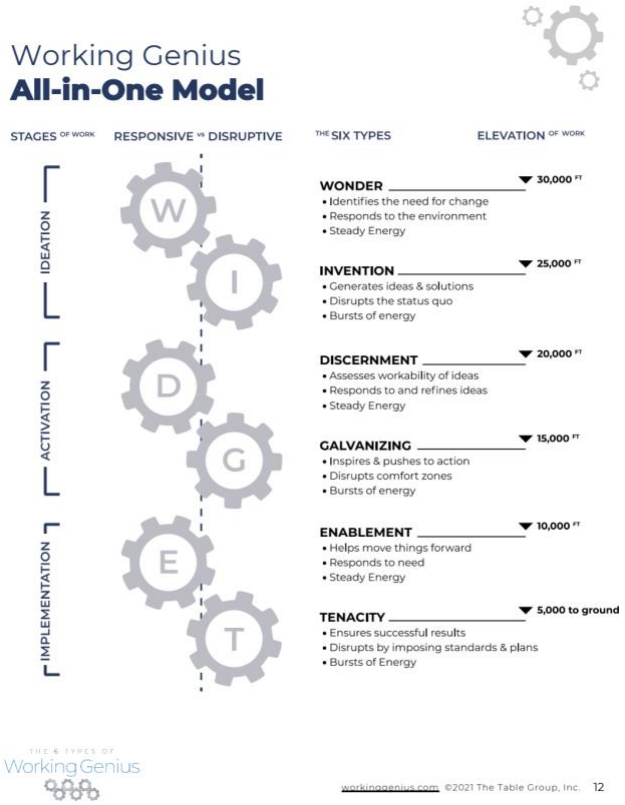


Figure 8: Working Genius model (Lencioni). I have strengths in the WT geniuses.

Over the course of the internship, my responsibilities grew to encompass a range of creative and communication-based tasks, including storytelling, generating social media campaigns, and organizing internal documentation. I created many visual promotional materials, authored blog posts and newsletters, and scaffolded LinkedIn campaigns. This blend of creative production and strategic communication gave me a well-rounded understanding of how different skills and work styles unite to support an organization's brand and mission. Throughout I maintained constant and consistent communication with the whole team, threaded by affirmation from beginning to end and easing me into a supportive, enjoyable role.

My classwork also played an important role in shaping my contributions:

- **PWRT 7043 Science & Health:** Because so many of MECC's practices are borrowed from health and wellness studies, my experience learning to write about these topics for general audiences (particularly through brief social media posts) proved invaluable. I combined the precise language used in Science & Health with the interpersonal, gentle voice of MECC to produce text that was accessible to individuals seeking professional guidance and consultations.
- **PWRT 7045 Web Design:** Many of the products I created for MECC were graphics adapted to a website format (like the newsletter) or flyers on social media. I often recalled lessons on the CRAP design principles I learned in this class, especially noting the cohesive visual identity of MECC branding across flyers and social media posts I designed.

Ultimately, this internship served as a formative educational experience that extended beyond what can be learned in a classroom. The sense of collaboration and inclusivity inherent to working in a small, women-led consulting organization was incredibly refreshing. The nature of our work meant discussions of mental health and honest communication were top priorities at all points of the internship, and this team offered me first-hand exposure to healthy workplace dynamics, collaborative decision-making, and professional creative liberty. These lessons will continue to inform my approach as I move toward a writing career in industry where understanding both the human and structural elements of teamwork will be essential to my success and happiness.

Advice for MECC

In reflecting on this experience, I provide recommendations for the next intern MECC invites to the team, should they decide to. These are informed by the experiences that were most informative for me, cultivating my understanding of consulting and workplace practices.

While onboarding future interns, MECC might consider deliberately introducing the organization's consulting practices and frameworks. I learned most about MECC's consulting techniques by observing team sessions in real time and seeing how those methods were applied in practice. For example, seeing the University of Cincinnati Corrections Institute team open an honest dialogue about their workplace culture in the "wisdom circle" helped me understand exactly what MECC's circle technique was and how it could help team members actively listen to one another. Future interns would benefit from an intentional onboarding process that explains these practices early on—perhaps through a brief orientation, workshop, or past case materials.

I also learned a great deal by reviewing documentation from previous team retreats, including schedules, reports, and photos. Having access to these examples provided helpful insight into how retreats are structured and how MECC's values manifest across clients. When I drafted a case study of Kristi's work with Oberlin College, I pored through archived materials about their team retreats, including schedules, presentations, and personal notes. I was able to familiarize myself with a team I had never met, drafting a case study while learning the techniques and methods MECC utilizes with clients. Encouraging access to these kinds of materials could strengthen the understanding of future interns new to the consulting process.

As my own focus during the internship concerned writing and communication within our small team, I did not gain much exposure to the consulting industry as a whole. Though this was acceptable as I hope to become a copywriter or editor elsewhere, future interns with different goals might appreciate more context about the broader consulting landscape, perhaps through discussions, reference lists, or short informational sessions. Building in these options would allow interns to tailor their experience to their career objectives while still contributing meaningfully to the organization's projects.

Advice for Students

This section offers guidance for students considering internships that incorporate writing or design responsibilities. For Professional Writing students—and students of any discipline, really—who become interns, I urge you to arrive ready and willing to reflect on your workplace values. In my case, MECC invited diversity and celebrated holistic work-life being; they wanted incoming team members to bring their unique backgrounds and perspectives to the work. You will maximize your learning experience by approaching every project with curiosity and authenticity by sharing ideas openly, asking questions, and remaining receptive to feedback.

1. **Engage eagerly in team processes such as brainstorming sessions, meetings, and reflective check-ins.** These may feel unfamiliar at first, but they offer insight into how inclusive professional spaces operate and how authentic communication strengthens teamwork. Attending retreats or observing your supervisors and coworkers at work is especially valuable for understanding the organization's methods and culture in action. Be willing to do new things and give yourself grace—vulnerability is difficult, though it has the power to transform your work for the better.
2. **Take full advantage of the creative freedom you're given.** Whether you're designing, writing, or publishing on social media, your internship should be a space for experimentation and education. Final products I became very proud of began as whiteboard musings and evolved into a blog post, a social media campaign, and several flyers. Don't be afraid to bring your own voice to projects—your team should appreciate fresh ideas and thoughtful risk-taking.
3. **Finally, treat your internship as an educational opportunity that complements rather than replicates your classroom experiences.** You'll receive lessons about workplace dynamics, communication, and leadership that can't be taught in theory. Stay curious, collaborative, and reflective, and you'll leave with not only stronger professional skills but also a clearer sense of what teams and projects you want to seek in your future career.

Conclusion

My internship with MECC was an affirming and transformative experience. From the very beginning, the organization's intentional welcome ceremonies and enthusiasm set a precedent of inclusion and care that carried throughout my time on the team. I had never before experienced such open and genuine lines of communication in a workplace. The frequent check-ins created space for honesty and connection—I often found myself thinking mindfully, meditating on the present moment. Even the quiet, reflective pauses during retreats offered a refreshing contrast to the emphasis on rapid efficiency that defines much of today's professional world.

My academic coursework played a significant role in shaping how I engaged with this environment and contributed to MECC's work. As RPW classes emphasize audience awareness, rhetorical appeals, and use of multimedia across mediums, I felt eager and prepared to enter this role where I would be employing the skills I'd cultivated in school for years. Because MECC is an organization founded upon healthy workplace practices, I left the space equipped with a newfound confidence in my freshly-begun career.

Through this internship, I not only learned new professional skills but also a great deal about myself and what work can look like. The experience stood apart from any role I've held before, academia and industry alike. MECC showed me that meaningful work can be collaborative, creative, and grounded in care. It strengthened my confidence as a writer, designer, and young queer woman preparing to enter the professional world. As I move forward and begin applying to jobs, I'll carry with me the lessons of this environment and seek small, creative teams that value reflection, empathy, and authenticity, much like the MECC team that helped shape me.

Works Cited

Lencioni, Patrick (2022). Introduction to Working Genius. *The Table Group*. https://files.tablegroup.com/wp-content/uploads/2022/09/21090156/Introduction-to-The-Working-Genius.pdf

Internship Journal

Summer 2025

May 19 – 23

Date	Summary
Monday, 5/19	• First day! Met with Grace ◦ Discussed: email access, scheduling • Completed DiSC assessment
Tuesday, 8/20	• Reviewed onboarding document • Reviewed account logins, accessed Canva
Wednesday, 8/21	• Prepared moodboard for infographics
Thursday, 8/22	• Work retreat: first in-person meeting, full day team building and planning for Retreat Series

May 26 – 30

Date	Summary
Tuesday, 5/27	• Completed first draft of "Lead Like it Matters" calendar design for Retreat Series
Wednesday, 5/28	• Completed revision and created second draft of "Lead Like it Matters"
Thursday, 5/29	• Completed revision and created third draft of "Lead Like it Matters" • Met with Grace to discuss next items: flyers and blog

June 2 – 6

Date	Summary
Monday, 6/2	• Met with Grace, brainstorming for blogpiece
Tuesday, 6/3	• Flyer research • Blog research
Wednesday, 6/4	• Finished first draft of "Navigating Change"
Thursday, 6/5	• Finished second draft of "Navigating Change"

June 9 – 13

Date	Summary

Monday, 6/9	• Met with Meghan and Grace, discussed blog idea, flyers, and conferences • Selected first draft, revised with QR code and Leading Series title
Tuesday, 6/10	• Created all Learning Series flyers
Wednesday, 6/11	• Researched LinkedIn articles on job searching • Began drafting blog piece
Thursday, 6/12	• First 300 words complete, sent to Grace for feedback

June 16 – 20

Date	Summary
Monday, 6/16	• Met with Grace, brainstorming session for Leadership Coaching graphic + blog piece
Tuesday, 6/17	• Leadership Coaching graphic first draft
Wednesday, 6/18	• Blog drafting
Thursday, 6/19	• Leadership Coaching graphic feedback, revision
Friday, 6/20	• Second passage of blog complete

June 23 – 27

Date	Summary
Monday, 6/23	• Met with Grace • Leadership Coaching first and second draft (second is selected)
Tuesday, 6/24	• Researching and reviewing Oberlin documents
Wednesday, 6/25	• Initial conversation/brainstorming about Oberlin College case study with Kristi
Thursday, 6/26	• Final passage to blog
Friday, 6/27	• Finalize first blog draft, edit Leadership Coaching

June 30 – July 4

Date	Summary
Tuesday, 7/1	• Began Oberlin case study draft • Drafted Operating Instructions
Wednesday, 7/2	• Met with Kristi to discuss Oberlin
Thursday, 7/3	• Turn in Operating Instructions (and template)

July 7 – 11

Date	Summary
Monday, 7/7	• Oberlin case study draft
Tuesday, 7/8	• Met with Grace
Wednesday, 7/9	• Oberlin case study fin

July 14 – 18

Date	Summary
Monday, 7/14	• Started Flashback Friday calendar • Weekly check-in with Grace • Met with Kristi to discuss Oberlin edits
Tuesday, 7/15	• UCCI retreat
Thursday, 7/17	• Leadership Wisdom Circle flyer first draft complete • Check-out meeting

July 21 – 25

Date	Summary
Monday, 7/21	• Met with Meghan • LinkedIn banners for Learning Series
Tuesday, 7/22	• Blog revision
Wednesday, 7/23	• Design first part of Testimonies graphic
Thursday, 7/24	• Design full Testimonies graphic

July 28 – August 1

Date	Summary
Tuesday, 7/29	• Met with Grace • Draft Flashback Friday
Wednesday, 7/30	• Final edits Oberlin • Published blog, Surmounting the Job Hunt: Anecdotes of Home and Work
Thursday, 7/31	• Touch up Internship Journal
Friday, 8/1	• First Flashback Friday posted to LinkedIn

August 4 – 8

Date	Summary
Monday, 8/4	• Met with Grace
Wednesday, 8/6	• Draft Flashback Friday
Thursday, 8/7	• Draft retreat series poster board

August 11 – 15

Date	Summary
Monday, 8/11	• Met with Meghan and Grace • Access to WordPress • Finished retreat series poster
Wednesday, 8/13	• Flashback Friday August 15 – 22

Fall 2025

August 18 – 22

Date	Hours	Summary
Monday, 8/18	2	• Newsletter draft • New newsletter template • Weekly check-in
Tuesday, 8/19	1	• Newsletter finish
Friday, 8/22	3	• Completed social media calendar

Total hours worked: 6

August 25 – 29

Date	Hours	Summary
Monday, 8/25	1	• Began this internship journal • Sent email to team about fall availability, scheduled regular check-ins
Wednesday, 8/27	2	• Internship report formatting
Thursday, 8/28	2	• Weekly check-out • Flashback Friday

Total hours worked: 5

September 1 – 30

Date	Hours	Summary
Monday, 9/2	1	• Flashback Friday
Wednesday, 9/3	2	• Contacted Kate welcome graphic • Business card drafts
Thursday, 9/4	1	• Check-out
Monday, 9/8	1	• Business card edit
Wednesday, 9/18	1	• Check-in w/Meghan
Monday, 9/22	1	• Business card edit • Newsletter edit

Total hours worked: 7

October 1 – 31

Date	Hours	Summary
Wednesday, 10/8	1	• Internship report
Wednesday, 10/22	1	• Internship report
Tuesday, 10/28	2	• Internship report
Friday, 10/31	2	• Internship report

Total hours worked: 6

November 1 – December 12

Date	Hours	Summary
Monday, 11/3	1	• Internship report
Wednesday, 11/5	1	• Internship report
Wednesday, 11/13	2	• Internship report, sent to First Reader Dr. Xie
Monday, 11/24	1	• Internship report edits, meeting w Ellie and Malyn
Tuesday, 11/25	2	• Internship report edits
Wednesday, 11/26	2	• Internship report edits
Wednesday, 12/10	1	• Presentation
Friday, 12/12	1	• Internship report edits

Total hours worked: 11